

CHINESE SPYVERSE

China can potentially use its surveillance cameras to gather sensitive information. The West was the first to raise alarm and take action. India, too, needs to step up vigilance and block spying possibilities

Graphic by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

The West's war against Chinese CCTVs

UNITED STATES

★ Under National Defense Authorisation Act (NDAA), 2019, US department of commerce places Hikvision, Dahua, Huawei, ZTE Corp and Hytera on an 'Entity List' along with 26 other Chinese entities, prohibiting US-based businesses from exporting their products to them

★ In Nov. 2019, President Trump signs order prohibiting US firms and individuals from investing in Chinese firms with links to its military

★ In Mar. 2021, Federal Communications Commission (FCC) puts 5 Chinese firms among entities deemed national security threats

★ In Oct. 2021, US legislature passes Secure Equipment Act prohibiting FCC to authorise such companies. FCC implements it in Nov. 2022

UNITED KINGDOM

★ Leaked CCTV footage in June 2021 shows then health secretary Matt Hancock kissing an aide. The scandal forces Hancock to resign. Hikvision cameras were reportedly used inside his office, raising concerns of a China hand in the leak

★ In Nov. 2022, the UK instructs government departments to stop installing Chinese CCTVs in sensitive sites. The order targets firms like Hikvision, Dahua and Huawei

★ Most of the nation's police force is found to be using Chinese surveillance cameras

AUSTRALIA

★ In February 2022, Australia decides to remove Chinese-made surveillance equipment from defence sites, citing security fears



How China-made CCTV cameras can snoop

★ The System-on-Chip (SoC) of a camera is the control centre of the CCTV. It has a processor which operates under software instruction

★ The software is stored in Flash Memory and Read only Memory (ROM), known as 'firmware'

★ Flash Memory holds the main operating system (OS) as well as software apps that can run on the OS

★ Applications like motion/ face detection and voice alerts help sift through large amounts of image data. Such 'analytics' are either controlled by the camera SoC or embedded in it

★ Advanced surveillance cameras can decide which data to capture, and when to connect to the internet. All this is controlled by the firmware, which in turn is controlled by the SoC provider

How to prevent snooping

Any device connected to the internet can be hacked. This includes all cameras, wired or wireless. What's needed is a firewall between devices and the net connection

